Who will arrest Bhindranwale?

Lieutenant General S.K. Sinha was the GOC-in-C of the Western Command during that period. Within a couple of days of Bhindranwale's return to Chowk Mehta, the chief secretary of Punjab requested him to arrest Bhindranwale. When General Sinha told him that it was not the job of the army, the chief secretary reportedly requested him to lend army tanks to help the Punjab police to carry out the task. That odd request was obviously refused. A personal request to Lt Gen. Sinha by Chief Minister Darbara Singh in that respect also did not work.

Two days later, General Sinha's chief of staff received orders from the prime minister's office that the army had to arrest Bhindranwale and detailed a Gurkha battalion to carry out the task. When General Sinha came to know about it, he told his chief of staff to put the operation on hold. He then called Defence Minister R. Venkataraman and requested that he be allowed to discuss the matter with the prime minster before the orders were carried out. The next day General Sinha was informed by the defence minister that the army should stand down and the task would be assigned to the local police. [6]

Gurudwara Chowk Mehta was surrounded by Punjab police. Darbara Singh had sent three senior police officers to negotiate with Bhindranwale, who agreed to surrender on the afternoon of 20 September. Santokh Singh, a close confidante of Indira Gandhi's and president of the DSGMC, was also present at Chowk Mehta that day. He made a very provocative speech before Bhindranwale's arrest. Just before the appointed time Bhindranwale also made a speech, which was highly critical of the Punjab government. That led to firing by his followers soon after his arrest. In the exchange of fire that followed, seven persons were killed. Santokh Singh's presence and his provocative speech at Gurudwara Chowk Mehta were brought to the notice of Prime Minister Gandhi by Parkash Singh Badal on 22 September when she visited Chandigarh to address an all-party meeting. [7]

Bhindranwale was kept in detention in Ferozepur jail for some time and was later temporarily taken to a canal rest house near